

Published in SATURDAY EVENING POST

No.5 8th February, 1964.

over
15

A FLASHY LAWYER FOR OSWALD'S KILLER

by RICHARD WARREN LEWIS photographers JACK FIELDS/ANDY HANSON

A nationwide television audience saw Jack Ruby shoot down the presumed assassin of President John F. Kennedy. Now national attention is focused on Ruby's trial in Dallas -- and on the flamboyant and controversial attorney defending him, Melvin Belli.

CIRCA 3,000 WORDS

WORLD COPYRIGHT: CURTIS PUBLISHING
COMPANY OF AMERICA

Represented by CAMERA PRESS (TEXT & ILLUSTRATIONS) LONDON

A FLASHY LAWYER FOR OSWALD'S KILLER

by RICHARD WARREN LEWIS

photographers JACK FIELDS/ANDY HANSON

A nationwide television audience saw Jack Ruby shoot down the presumed assassin of President John F. Kennedy. Now national attention is focused on Ruby's trial in Dallas -- and on the flamboyant and controversial attorney defending him, Melvin Belli.

When Dallas nightclub operator Jack Ruby burst through police lines to shoot down Lee Harvey Oswald, the alleged assassin of President John F. Kennedy, he did what no man has every done before. He killed a man in the sight of millions of witnesses on television.

All across the country, twice-stunned Americans wondered what defense Ruby would or could make -- and who would conduct that defense. So did Ruby's family. His relatives sifted through dozens of applications and recommendations before making their choice: Melvin Mourn Belli (pronounced BELL-eye) -- one of the most successful, most controversial and most flamboyant of present-day trial lawyers.

Although he has defended a score of murderers in the past ten years -- successfully in all but two cases -- Belli is best known for his prowess in cases involving personal injury, a field in which he is widely regarded as preeminent. On over 100 occasions he has won his clients awards of more than \$100,000 -- sometimes much more -- and he is understandably unpopular with insurance companies, which have to pay these awards.

Some insurance men, in fact, feel that Belli, more than any other individual, is responsible for the sharp increase in liability-insurance rates during recent years. But Belli's detractors are not confined to the world of insurance. A second major group which feels no affection for him is the medical profession. In both personal-injury and malpractice cases -- another Belli specialty -- doctors frequently face him as witnesses called by the defense. "He's the type of man who, in cross-examination, tends to intimidate people," says Dr. Eugene Hoffman, a member of the house of delegates of the American Medical Association. "If a lawyer can upset an expert witness by making him contradict himself or answer questions partially or lose his temper, the expert is no good. Doctors don't like to be baited any more than anyone else."

But Belli is perhaps loved least of all by his colleagues in the law. "Some of his exhibitions simply don't comport with the ideals of American justice," says a Los Angeles attorney who has faced him often in court. Probably the most spectacular of Belli's exhibitions in his custom of celebrating court

continued